

UK Ministry Snapshot

Through the Eyes of Pastor Bert Han

the Birmingham Chinese Evangelical Church (BCEC) – Birmingham, UK

Interviewed by Pastor Enoch Liao | CCCOWE 2026 Explore360, Kuching, Malaysia

Pastor Bert Han was born in Southern California but moved to the UK straight after university and has been ministering with Chinese heritage churches there for 30 years. He spent his early years with COCM (Chinese Overseas Christian Mission), the organization that helped plant and establish many of the Chinese churches now spread across the UK. For the past 24 years he has served at the Birmingham Chinese Evangelical Church (BCEC) in Birmingham — England's second largest city — where he now serves as senior pastor. The BCEC runs four sites with five services: two Cantonese, one Mandarin, and two English in the Birmingham city center, plus a Cantonese/Mandarin congregation in Telford, about an hour to the west.

Bert speaks from 30 years in one context. What follows is not a survey. It is one seasoned pastor's account of what he has seen, navigated, and learned.

▪ Who Are the People? Three Waves of Immigration

The BCEC's congregation is not one community. It is several, each shaped by a different wave of migration.

The founding wave — late 1970s and 1980s. Primarily Southeast Asian immigrants and Hong Kongers who came to the UK for the catering trade. Many worked takeaways. The BCEC itself was founded in the basement of a restaurant: Pastor Frank Jern held Bible studies starting at 1 or 2 in the morning, after the takeaways closed, as an alternative to the casino. That is how the church came about.

The scholars. The BCEC's Mandarin congregation grew primarily from mainland Chinese students who came to Birmingham for master's degrees and PhDs and chose to stay. A different profile, a different register, a different culture — even within the same building.

The English congregation. A mix of international students who stayed after graduation and local-born Chinese heritage people. Holding this group is its own pastoral challenge, one that every Chinese heritage church in the English-speaking world knows well.

The BNO wave — 2021 to present. This is the story dominating the UK Chinese church right now. Britain's British National Overseas visa program opened a pathway to residency and citizenship for Hong Kongers, and the response has been massive. Estimates put the number of BNO visa applicants across the UK at just under 200,000, with around 20,000 in the Birmingham region alone.

The arrivals did not distribute randomly. Many chose their neighborhoods based on YouTube videos made by Hong Kong influencers — house tours, school reviews, city walkthroughs. "Why did you choose to live here?" Bert would ask. The answer: "We found Hong Kongers were making videos about this area, so we all moved there."

For churches, the effect was sudden and overwhelming. Cantonese ministries that had been quietly aging out — losing musicians, moving to YouTube worship for their small remaining congregations, unsure of their future — found themselves flooded. Bert describes it: "We were slowly sunseting our Cantonese ministry. A lot of them were retiring, slowly starting to move toward YouTube for their worship because there were no musicians. And then suddenly — just tons of people."

"It was really interesting. We were under COVID restrictions. Some Hong Kongers had moved here prior to COVID and they were under restrictions. As soon as we opened up church again, it was packed. They came in, and every week it was 30 or 40 new people. Your WhatsApp group immediately filled up to hundreds."

From one Cantonese service headed for YouTube to five Cantonese services — that is the arc of the past four years.

▪ What Are the Hardest Tensions?

Racial dynamics, past and present. Earlier in Bert's ministry, racial abuse was more common and more visible — slurs on the street, dismissive gestures. "White Christian missionaries working in the UK who look at you and say, 'I want to say something Chinese to you' — and then they say something, and they mean well, but the ignorance level is so high." Birmingham's multi-ethnic character has made this less frequent than in more homogeneous parts of the country, but the underlying dynamic has not disappeared.

The spectrum of local British churches. On one end: a church told Bert his congregation's overflow should "just come to us — we don't think you should have your own Chinese ethnic church." On the other end: invitations from majority-culture churches asking Bert to come coach them on how to welcome Hong Kongers — "we don't want to be racist, but we don't know what we don't know." That second response would not have happened 20 years ago. The fact that it is happening now is real, meaningful change.

"I said something simple: when you meet someone, ask them about their family. Ask them how their kids are doing. And I remember this white couple looked at me and said, 'What? I never thought about that. I just wanted to have been to Hong Kong.' I said: you should just treat them like a normal person."

Grief among new arrivals. Many Hong Kongers sold everything to leave. Some did not tell their children they were moving until they were already on the way. Some are political refugees who cannot return. The grief is real and ongoing. One brother told Bert last week: "Hong Kong culture is dying. It'll die out soon. I can see it every time I go back. And I look at my daughter — she's not going to be a Hong Konger at all."

The merger dynamic. The influx has felt less like a revival and more like a corporate acquisition: a large company moved all its employees to a small company overnight. A Cantonese congregation of 30 people that built the church over decades suddenly found itself host to 80 newcomers from large Hong Kong megachurches — with high expectations ("Why is your building so small? Build seven stories!") and different denominational cultures. The original members felt like strangers in their own church.

Denominational and political diversity under one roof. Birmingham now has eight or so Chinese churches where it used to have two. Some of the newer ones are more explicitly pro-democracy in their posture — holding protests and memorials. Others, like the BCEC, have taken a different approach. All of them are trying to figure out how to coexist in the same city.

The future-generation question. This may be the longest-burning tension. None of the Hong Kongers who have arrived have ever raised a child who does not speak their language. Hong Kong pastors who barely held their second generation in Hong Kong — where at least the language was shared — now face that same challenge from day one in the UK. "It's going to be a bigger challenge. There are a lot of questions about what's going to happen in the future."

▪ What Does a Healthy Chinese Heritage Church Look Like?

Bert does not claim to have the model. He describes two questions he uses to take the temperature of his own church.

First: Does the congregation value Christ over its cultural defaults?

"Chinese culture — we're really good at discipline, and shame, and math. But we're not so good at grace." A healthy church does not suppress Chinese culture but refuses to let cultural norms overrule Christ. Bert's litmus tests: Are we generous? Are we possessive over resources? Are we holding family in a healthy way, or in a way that has become idolatrous? "When I've seen Chinese churches struggle, it's when they prioritize cultural values over Christ."

Second: Can each language congregation evangelize, encourage, and empower effectively in its own community?

The BCEC has three distinct congregations. Bert's question for each of them is not "are they conforming to the same model?" but "can they bring people in their circle to faith and to community — and are they glad to?" Unity does not mean uniformity. The goal is to empower each congregation to do what it needs to do, not to impose one approach on all three.

He adds a structural note that he sees as important: in the US, the English congregation in a Chinese church is often treated as the child of the founding congregation — and in a Chinese family dynamic, children are not allowed to grow up into independence. The BCEC tries to operate as siblings instead. "Three siblings — and we want to bless each other. The best part is we can all learn from each other's strengths and weaknesses."

The result is something Bert thinks is rarer than people acknowledge: a church that is genuinely multi-lingual, multi-generational, multi-national, multi-class, and politically diverse. "More actual diversity than most 'multiracial' majority-culture churches — which are really one culture, even if they're multiracial."

▪ Becoming a Spiritual Home for Politically Wounded Hong Kongers

This is the live pastoral challenge of the BNO moment. Bert's church made a deliberate early decision about where to stand.

The BCEC has not become a politically activist church. But it has not ignored the pain either. The posture Bert describes: empathize with the grief, but pray for transformation rather than treating anyone as the enemy. "Our prayers tend to lean toward salvation — to come to those in leadership in the Communist Party, things like that. We really try to lean into what it looks like to love our enemy. Bless those who persecute you. Bless and do not curse."

He is clear this is not the only legitimate posture. Some of the newer Hong Kong-style churches are more explicitly political, and Bert blesses them: "We're not against them. We're happy for all the churches to exist. We bless you." He sees the ecosystem of Chinese churches in Birmingham — from the BCEC's approach to the more politically active congregations — as a healthy range, not a competition.

Pastorally, the listening matters as much as the theology. One brother's lament — "Hong Kong culture is dying" — is not a political statement to be corrected. It is grief to be received.

There is also a pragmatic complexity underneath it all. Some Hong Kongers may return to Hong Kong once they secure UK citizenship — the BNO visa as a "get out of jail free card," citizenship for the option to leave when needed. Others sold everything and have no path back financially. The church holds both of these realities without forcing them into one narrative.

▪ What Does the Chinese Church Have to Offer Britain?

Bert resists the frame of the question.

"When I came 30 years ago, the state of British churches was even worse — a lot of them were really dying. Back then, the debate on whether English ministries in Chinese churches need to exist didn't matter here, because you needed any good church you could get."

The state of Christianity in the UK is better now than it was — still on a slow decline by the numbers, but better than 30 years ago. His answer to "what can the Chinese church offer the Anglo church?" is to step back from the offer/receive frame entirely: any church making genuine disciples provides integral value to the society it is in. Full stop. "Every more Christian in society makes it better — in teaching, in healthcare, in janitorial work, as a bus driver."

His bottom line: "If you make a church that you like going to — I like going to my church. I'm on sabbatical right now and I already miss it. If I go there and I encounter God, I have community, I see lives changed — that's all we're looking for."

He is genuinely hopeful about the Chinese church in the UK. The BNO wave has brought a new generation of families who need to be discipled, and the need is urgent. There are non-Christian Hong Kongers who have arrived and have no church. There are children being raised in a country where their parents have no template for what comes next. The Chinese church in the UK has not arrived at a settled equilibrium. It is in the middle of something. Bert is more hopeful than anxious about what that something could become.

Pastor Bert Han serves as senior pastor of the Birmingham Chinese Evangelical Church (BCEC), Birmingham, UK. He has been in Chinese heritage church ministry in the UK for 30 years. This snapshot is drawn from an interview conducted by Pastor Enoch Liao on June 3, 2026, in preparation for the CCCOWE 2026 Explore360 breakout session.